

Introduction

Strategy from constraint is the practice of using limitations to our advantage, and if possible, creating such constraints which lead to better throughput. Instead of viewing constraints as obstacles, this approach treats them as mechanisms that shape behavior, focus effort, and generate alignment.

Sun Tzu was an ancient Chinese military strategist and philosopher, best known as the traditional author of **The Art of War**. His work dates back to the 5th century BCE and demonstrates multiple forms of strategic thinking. In this memo, we will be looking at his depictions of "Strategy from Constraints", especially from **Chapter 11: The Nine Situations** from The Art of War.

Burn the ships

I. The Constraints:

- **Survival instincts:** Soldiers and humans naturally avoid risk and seek safety. When alternatives exist, they will prioritize survival over victory. The availability of escape routes creates fragmentation of intent and weakens collective action.
- **Desire:** *"Wealth and long life are things for which all men have a natural inclination."* Hence, soldiers are not inherently self-sacrificing; they act based on incentives.
- **Situational constraint (no escape):** *"Throw your soldiers into positions whence there is no escape."* This creates an absolute condition: survival depends only on fighting. Without structural pressure, coordination must be enforced externally (orders, discipline, command).

II. The Strategy

The underlying strategy is: Constraints can be created to bring out the best version. This can be done by **eliminating optionality (especially retreat) to force irreversible commitment**.

This idea is not a single action, but a sequence of reasoning steps about how people behave under pressure and how a leader can shape that behavior:

1. Humans naturally avoid risk and choose safety when options exist. Hesitation or retreat is not a lack of ability, but a result of having alternatives.
2. The strategy removes these alternatives by eliminating retreat and escape, forcing everyone to face the same unavoidable situation.
3. This makes the situation irreversible, where survival depends entirely on action. As Sun Tzu states, **"Place your army in deadly peril, and it will survive."**
4. At this point, survival and success become identical as there is no longer a trade-off between saving oneself and achieving the objective. Because everyone is now facing the same condition, coordination begins to happen on its own. As described, **'Without waiting to be marshaled... without orders, they can be trusted.'** Hence natural alignment and maximum effort is achieved without the need for strict control.

III. Why is this a Strategy from Constraints?

- **Removing choice alters behavior:** When people are given options, especially between safety and risk, they tend to choose safety. This often leads to hesitation, retreat, or reduced effort. By removing these choices entirely, the strategy directly shapes behavior. As Sun Tzu notes, **“If there is no place of refuge, they will stand firm.”** The constraint itself forces action.
- **Eliminating internal conflict:** Normally, a soldier faces a dilemma between self-preservation and duty. This internal conflict weakens decision-making. When there is no escape, this conflict disappears because there is only one viable path left. Fighting is no longer a decision—it becomes a necessity, leading to clarity and decisiveness.
- **Designing advantage through constraint:** This is a true example of strategy from constraint because the limitation is not avoided but deliberately created. By removing escape, Sun Tzu transforms fear, self-interest, and desire for safety into commitment, unity, and strength. Instead of controlling individuals directly, he designs the environment so that the constraint itself produces the desired outcome.

Conclusion

Sun Tzu’s central insight in this framework is that effective strategy can also emerge from carefully designing constraints that shape behavior. By removing the option of retreat, he eliminates hesitation and internal conflict, forcing individuals to align their actions with the collective goal.

Fear is not eliminated but redirected, choice is not expanded but reduced, and through this, unity and maximum effort become inevitable. In this way, constraint is not treated as a limitation to be overcome, but as a deliberate strategic tool which converts human tendencies into sources of strength and makes commitment not a matter of will, but a result of design.

References & Acknowledgements

1. “The Art of War” by Sun Tzu, Apple Books.
2. Use of AI: I used ChatGPT for initial memo drafting.